



History of gunpowder

The Chinese understood the explosive properties of gunpowder—a mixture of saltpeter, sulfur, and charcoal—as early as the 9th century CE. They adapted its use to military purposes, producing “fire-arrows,” rockets, and flamethrowers. Around 1250, they made the first cannons. Knowledge of gunpowder weaponry spread westward, reaching Europe about 1300. Cannons soon appeared in battles there. Within a hundred years, handheld guns were developed, but it was early artillery — the big guns—that proved most effective in sieges, where they could demolish fortifications once thought indestructible. There was no such success for the French at the so-called Mahdia Crusade pictured here, as their firepower was not sufficient to breach city walls.



“It made such a noise in the going, as though all the devils of hell had been on the way.”

Jean Froissart, *Chronicles*, giving an account of the use of cannons at the siege of Oudenaarde, in Flanders, 1382